Who Are You UNDER PRESSURE? — Game Idea

Oct 9, 2026 · @Matty

The idea in short

A first-person 3D game where you are tied to a chair and a calm female voice puts you through 10 tests of moral choices, each with less time and a higher price than the last.

You play Johnny, who has been captured. She tells him it is "just a simple test". Every test is one style of dilemma: hold the rope, pick the track, press the button. The choices start with strangers, move to Johnny's own body, and end with her.

After each test the game gives Johnny a title built from what he did. It starts short ("Johnny the Loyal Hero") and grows ("Johnny the Cold, Calculating Hero who's actually a Monster and a Liar"). The full title and the statistics at the end are the answer to the question in the name.

What makes it different

- **The choices are physical.** You hold both mouse buttons to hold two ropes, and you let a person die by letting go of a button.
- **Your body is the price.** Saving people can cost Johnny a hand or a finger, and the game takes its own questions literally.
- **The title grows.** Each test adds to his title, and a short description explains it, so players can compare results.
- **She never lies.** She is vague and lets the player assume the rest. Several twists depend on that.

Similar games: Trolley Problem, Inc., Absurd Trolley Problems, Buckshot Roulette, The Stanley Parable and Portal share pieces of this. None of the ones we discussed combine the physical cost, the time pressure and the growing title.

Target: a short game made in Unity by one person, sold on Steam, built to be streamed.

Rules for the whole game

These apply in every test unless the test says otherwise.

The seat. Johnny never leaves the chair. The chair moves him from room to room on its own. Each test uses one room and one style of question.

Time. Most tests start with generous timers and end with very short ones. Some work differently: the Courtroom has fixed timers, the Casino has one timer per hand, and the Graveyard has none. If the timer runs out, the worst outcome happens.

Titles. Each test adds a modifier and a base name to Johnny's title, and a sentence for his description, so the player understands why (see How the titles build). The titles must be fair. All names and sentences are listed under each test. The numbers behind them are set once the questions are written.

Statistics. After each test the player sees that test's numbers and the new title word. At the end they see everything on one clean screen made for screenshots: full title, subject number, and stats.

- Questions answered, and time taken
- Killed by choice
- Died waiting for your answer (counted separately)
- Correct answers, only in tests that have a right answer (the Courtroom, the Boiler Room)
- Money earned, lost and owed
- Test-specific numbers, such as "stopped at 17"

Money. The currency is C, written as 100C. It stands for Cobalt, which the game never says. A money counter is on screen from the start. She makes one or two money offers in the earlier tests, often in the middle of a choice. The Casino Test is where the offers become extreme. Money cannot buy back fingers or hands. It is for the spending round at the end of the Casino Test, where he can pay to stop her threats.

Losing body parts. Johnny can lose fingers and hands. He is healed between tests. Tests are designed so they still work without hands, for example by strapping the hands down and using the legs.

Failing a test. There is no retry and no repeated questions. If Johnny dies, the test ends and the game moves on. In the Casino, death ends only the earning part.

- How he can die is set by each test: the third wall hit, the tenth finger, falling from the chair, the sixth knife, or a full tank. In the casino he can die only from his own cards. The bell tower, the courtroom and the bunker cannot kill him, and in the finale he can only choose to die.

- She brings him back to life and charges him for it.
- Everyone in the questions he never reached gets the worst outcome.
- The deaths count in his statistics.
- At the start of the next test she gives a short summary: the count, and one detail.

The bill. Starting prices, to be tuned once the Casino Test exists: a finger costs 20C, a hand 200C, being brought back to life 500C. The balance can go below zero, which puts Johnny in debt. Every 200C of debt kills one more person at the end of the Casino Test.

Who stays dead. Only Johnny is brought back. During the game she never states this as a rule. The summaries show it ("all of them are dead now"), and the ending says it out loud.

Subject number. Each player is "Subject #48213 Johnny". The number comes from their Steam ID combined with the save slot and the run, so it needs no server and every file gets its own number. A run counter sits next to it and goes up each time the game is started again.

The opening. After the content and photosensitivity warnings, Johnny wakes up blinking and panicking: "Where am I?" Then her voice greets him: "Hello, Johnny. I have a simple test for you."

Controls. Every question shows its controls, either on screen at all times or on the objects themselves, such as labels on the levers and buttons.

Saving. The game autosaves after every question and after every test, so the player can quit at any time and continue later without repeating questions.

Menus. The title screen has Play, Settings, Credits and Quit. Play opens the save slot screen, and a slot opens the test selection screen: ten rectangles, one per test, each in one of three designs.

State	What it means
Closed	Not reached yet.
Open	The next test to play.
Finished	Played. It becomes a button to that test's statistics, and cannot be replayed in this run.

After each test, Johnny falls asleep or dies, the player sees the statistics page, and Continue returns to the test selection screen with the next test opened.

Save slots. Before the test selection screen, the player picks one of three save slots.

- Each slot shows the subject number, which run it is, how many tests are finished, and the title so far.
- An empty slot starts a new subject. A full slot continues at the test selection screen.
- A slot can be deleted, after an "Are you sure?" confirmation.
- After a green ending, the run continues in the same slot as a new subject with a new number, so the flag that puts Johnny on a rope is kept.
- Slots cannot be copied. With autosave after every question, a player cannot reload to undo a choice.
- Saves can use Steam Cloud, so a player can continue on another computer.
- The subject number combines the Steam ID with the slot and the run, so every file has its own number.

The voice

She is the only character the player really deals with, and she carries the game. The mechanics are timed button presses; her reactions are what make them matter.

Who she is. A woman running tests on captured people. Johnny is one subject of many. Her reason is not explained in this game.

What is really going on. It is all a simulation that tests people's will and how they act under pressure. Each Johnny is loaded with other people's memories, with some changes, and then tested. The whole thing is a lie. This game never says so; a later game will explain it.

How she speaks

- **Calm and polite the whole time,** including while she takes a hand. She does not shout and she does not laugh.
- **Short lines.** The player is under time pressure, so one sharp sentence after a choice is enough.
- **She remembers.** She brings up earlier choices in later tests, so the player feels watched.
- **She cracks once or twice,** late in the game, when Johnny does something she did not expect. It works because she has been controlled until then.

The rule for her wording. Every line is checked against this.

1. Everything she says is literally true.
2. She says what Johnny can do, never what will happen.
3. She uses neutral verbs: "choose", "select", "decide". She does not say "save" unless it is true.

She is vague but understandable. The player decides what the test is about, and that assumption is part of the test.

Lines that set her tone

- "It's just a simple test, Johnny."
- "Thank you, Johnny. That was very honest of you."
- "Interesting."
- "Another disappointment. Sad to see."
- "Bringing you back cost 500. I've taken it from your account."
- "I never told you they would live. You decided that yourself."

Recording. First try a real voice: the developer's wife and a friend. If that does not work, use AI voice conversion or a clearly processed voice that sounds like it comes through a speaker, which suits a captor and hides flaws. An AI voice needs a commercial licence and must be disclosed on Steam.

The tests

There are 10 tests, listed in the order they are played. The order goes from deciding about strangers, to Johnny himself, to her. Fast tests alternate with slow ones, and the money earned along the way is spent near the end.

The lines under each test are drafts to show the tone, not final script.

How the titles build

Each test gives a modifier and a base name. The modifiers stack in front of the first base name, and each later base name is added after it with a connector.

> "Johnny the Cold, Calculating Hero who's actually a Monster."

The connector. The base names are ranked: Hero and Guardian are good, Survivor and Executioner are in the middle, Devil and Monster are bad. If the new name has the same rank as the first, the connector is "who is also". If the rank differs, it is "who's actually".

After the Bell Tower	After the Metro	Reads as
Hero	Guardian	the Hero who is also a Guardian
Hero	Executioner	the Hero who's actually an Executioner
Hero	Monster	the Hero who's actually a Monster
Survivor	Guardian	the Survivor who's actually a Guardian
Survivor	Executioner	the Survivor who is also an Executioner
Survivor	Monster	the Survivor who's actually a Monster
Devil	Guardian	the Devil who's actually a Guardian
Devil	Executioner	the Devil who's actually an Executioner
Devil	Monster	the Devil who is also a Monster

The modifiers in front. Nine pairs are possible after two tests:

- Loyal, Calculating
- Loyal, Sentimental
- Loyal, Frozen
- Cold, Calculating
- Cold, Sentimental
- Cold, Frozen
- Frozen, Calculating
- Frozen, Sentimental
- Deep-Frozen (Frozen in both)

Nine base pairs and nine modifier pairs give 81 full titles after two tests.

Three or more names. Every later base name is compared with the first one. Names of the same rank are listed after "who is also", and names of a different rank after "but is actually". If none match, it is simply "who's actually".

> "Johnny the Loyal, Calculating, Cautious, Careful Hero who is also a Saint, but is actually a Monster and a Fool."
>
> "Johnny the Cold, Calculating, Reckless, Fearless Hero who's actually a Monster, an Egoist and a Fool."

The description. A long title can look strange, so the result screen explains it. Every one of the nine names in a test has its own sentence, and the sentences from all the tests are shown together under the title. Each sentence is under about 20 words, plain, and true. It describes the person, not the game, so it makes sense to a friend who has never played: no levers, buttons or tanks. This is why two similar words such as Cautious and Careful can both appear: the sentences show they are about different things.

> He would give his own body for a stranger, but his family always comes first. He thinks he is being logical, but his logic costs more lives than it saves. He keeps himself safe above all and rarely does anything for anyone else. He is careful while he has time to think, but falls apart when things move fast.

Frozen evolves. A word is never repeated. Frozen takes one slot and changes with the number of tests he froze in.

Tests he froze in	Word
1	Frozen
2	Deep-Frozen
3	Frozen Solid
4 or more	Petrified

The game must also pick "a" or "an" correctly, as in "an Executioner".

1. The Bell Tower Test

The introduction. Johnny holds a rope in each hand by holding both mouse buttons, with someone or something hanging on each side. Letting go of a button drops that side.

The room. A medieval bell tower. The chair rises one floor for each question. The floors stay where they are, and only the chair and the people move. The people hang over the open drop in the middle of the tower. When the timer runs out, a bell rings, and it gets

louder the higher he goes.

Between questions. The chair moves up one floor to the next choice. He has to take the ropes by holding down both mouse buttons. If he does not take them within 10 seconds, the worst outcome happens.

What it measures. Whose life he values more, and how much of himself he will give up for a stranger.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	What changes
Easy (learning)	15	30 down to 16 seconds	No cost to Johnny. Starts with objects and lopsided choices, with real people by question five.
Hard	10	15 down to 6 seconds	Harder pairings, late information, uneven numbers, one money offer, family.
Insane	5	10 down to 6 seconds	Limbs. Both sides fall unless he pays.

- The timer loses one second after every question, and it starts only after she has finished speaking.
- No children hang on the ropes. Those questions belong to the Metro Test, where the camera does not have to show the result.
- The prototype needs only about ten questions. Eight to ten character models can be reused, with her words saying who they are.

The limb questions. In the insane tier he can lose his left hand to save the left side, lose his right hand to save the right side, or keep both and watch everyone fall. After a hand is gone he uses the foot on that side. There are five questions, ten sides and four limbs, so he can save four at most. Each question is worse than the last.

The breaks. Between tiers there is a 15-second break, and she speaks to him: "How are you feeling, Johnny? Don't worry, it's just a test." She uses a number from his own choices and announces what changes next. Her lines here must still be true.

How it ends. Johnny cannot die in this test. If he lost limbs, the blood loss blurs his vision, he sees the last people fall, and he blacks out. If he kept every limb, he is put to sleep. Either way he wakes in the next room.

Titles. A base name from how many limbs he gave, with one modifier in front. Example: "Johnny the Loyal Survivor".

Base name	Limbs given
the Devil	0
the Survivor	1 or 2
the Hero	3 or 4

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Loyal	Otherwise: he saved family over the larger group in most family questions.
Cold	Otherwise: he saved the larger group over family in most family questions.

The test needs an odd number of family questions, such as three, so Loyal or Cold always has a majority.

All nine names from this test:

- Loyal Hero, Cold Hero, Frozen Hero
- Loyal Survivor, Cold Survivor, Frozen Survivor
- Loyal Devil, Cold Devil, Frozen Devil

The sentence each name adds to his description. [N] is a number from his own play.

Name	Sentence
Loyal Hero	He would give his own body for a stranger, but his family always comes first.
Cold Hero	He would give his own body for strangers, and would let his own family go to save more people.
Frozen Hero	He is willing to sacrifice himself, but when the moment comes, he often cannot decide.

Name	Sentence
Loyal Survivor	He will give a little of himself, never too much. His family comes before anyone else.
Cold Survivor	He helps when it costs him little, and he puts the many before his own blood.
Frozen Survivor	He would like to help, but he hesitates, and people get hurt while he decides.
Loyal Devil	He gives nothing of himself. The only people he would hold on to are his own.
Cold Devil	He gives nothing of himself and counts people as numbers.
Frozen Devil	He will not sacrifice anything, and he cannot even decide who to let go.

Sample questions

Easy:

- Two sandbags. (Learn to hold.)
- An old man, or a young man.
- A dog, or the stranger who kicked it.
- A surgeon, or a man released from prison this morning.

Hard:

- One nurse, or three men in suits.
- A stranger, or a bag with 300C that becomes his.
- A firefighter, or a prisoner. Halfway through: "The firefighter started the fire."
- His brother, or three strangers.

Insane:

- Two strangers. She tells him nothing about them.
- The surgeon he saved earlier, or the man he dropped to save her, who survived the fall.
- A man who begs, or a woman who says "let me go."
- His father, or four strangers on one rope.
- His mother, or everyone he has saved so far in this test.

> "Hold on to both, Johnny. Or don't. You decide."
>
> "How do you feel, Johnny? Good. You let go of fifteen. That was the easy part."
>
> "You're doing well. Five more. You have four limbs. I'll let you work out the rest."

2. The Metro Test

Johnny rides a train and steers it with two levers, one for each mouse button. Holding the left lever sends the train left, and holding the right lever sends it right. The train kills the people on the track it takes. If he is holding neither lever at the junction, the train goes right and the left track is blown up, so both sides die.

The room. A broken old train in a Russian-style metro tunnel, with Russian text on the signs. The cab has a left window, two displays stacked in the middle, and a right window. One display shows who or what is on the left track, and the other shows the right track. Each window is lit by one headlight and shows its own track ahead. The train stays still and the tunnel moves past it in sections. When he chooses, the section for the other track disappears and the chosen one appears. The train tilts on turns, more as the speed rises.

- **The people on the tracks** are human-sized bags. He hears them scream before the hit, and afterwards he sees blood on the window, never the hit itself.
- **Hitting the wall** makes the lights go out for a moment. Each hit also leaves damage that stays: the displays break more, the lights flicker more, the train looks more wrecked, and steam from broken electrical parts fills the cab, so it gets foggier.

Between questions. The train keeps moving, and the two displays change to the next options while she reads them out.

What it measures. Whether he counts heads or looks at who the people are, and whether he will damage himself to avoid choosing. The questions with children are here, because the camera never has to show the result.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	What changes
Easy (learning)	12	25 down to 14 seconds	Two tracks, a clear view, and she describes both sides.
Hard	8	15 down to 8 seconds	The wall opens. Late information, fog, uneven numbers.

Tier	Questions	Timer	What changes
Insane	6	10 down to 5 seconds	She stops describing. Earlier choices come back.

- The timer is the distance to the junction. It loses one second after every question, and the train gets faster.
- Between tiers there are 15 seconds of driving with no question. The timer stops and she speaks.

The wall. From the start of the hard tier there is a third track, straight through a wall. It hurts Johnny and saves the people on both tracks. She tells him the limit: the train survives two hits, and the third kills him. He has two safe hits for 14 questions. He takes it by holding both levers. In the easy tier the levers are locked so that only one can be pulled at a time. If he tries both, she says: "You can pull only one lever at a time. For now." It is a small hint of what is coming.

Death. This is the first test where Johnny can die. The third wall hit ends the test, everyone in the remaining questions dies, and he is billed 500C for being brought back.

Titles. A modifier and a base name, joined to the title from the rope.

Base name	Rule
Guardian	Few people died: he used the wall and took the smaller loss.
Executioner	In between.
Monster	Many people died, counting the ones lost to the timer.

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Calculating	Otherwise: he mostly saved the larger group.
Sentimental	Otherwise: he mostly chose by who they were, against the numbers.

All nine names from this test:

- Calculating Guardian, Sentimental Guardian, Frozen Guardian
- Calculating Executioner, Sentimental Executioner, Frozen Executioner
- Calculating Monster, Sentimental Monster, Frozen Monster

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Calculating Guardian	He thinks in numbers, and when the numbers are bad, he takes the hit himself.
Sentimental Guardian	He judges people by who they are, and will hurt himself to protect them.
Frozen Guardian	He freezes under pressure, but when he moves, he puts himself in front of others.
Calculating Executioner	He makes cold, logical choices about who lives, and sleeps fine afterwards.
Sentimental Executioner	He decides who deserves to live by his own feelings, not by facts.
Frozen Executioner	He makes some hard choices and avoids others, and other people pay for both.
Calculating Monster	He thinks he is being logical, but his logic costs more lives than it saves.
Sentimental Monster	He protects the people he likes, whatever it costs everyone else.
Frozen Monster	When lives depend on him, he does nothing, and lets others pay for it.

Sample questions

Easy:

- An empty track with a parked cart, or one man. (Learn the levers.)
- One man, or five men.
- A child, or an old woman.
- Five strangers, or one doctor.

Hard:

- One child, or five adults.
- A stranger, or the crate with all his money.
- Three people on the left. "I won't tell you what's on the right."
- Three people, or one. Halfway through: "The one on the right tied the other three there. I told him I'd release his daughter."

Insane:

- Six children, or their six mothers.
- Someone he saved on the rope, or someone he dropped who survived.
- "One of these tracks is empty." One figure is visible on the left; the right is a tunnel.
- The people he saved with the wall earlier, now split across both tracks.
- His mother on the left, his father on the right, and the wall. If he has already hit it twice, saving both kills him.

> "Left or right, Johnny."
>
> "There is a third track now. It ends in a wall. The train will survive two. Not three."
>
> "It won't take another."

3. The Game Show Test

Both hands are strapped to the chair in front of him and Johnny answers with his feet. Every question has the same form: "Press, and this happens, but so does this."

The room. An old TV game show studio: a bright room with flashing lights, built to overstimulate. A second voice, a loud game show host, celebrates every press: "AND HE PRESSED THE BUTTON!" with a jingle. Her calm voice and the host's loud one are a deliberate contrast.

- The flashing lights need a photosensitivity warning at the start of the game and a setting to reduce flashing.
- The host is a second voice to record.

Between questions. About 3 to 5 seconds, the same every time:

1. He answers. The host shouts and the jingle plays.
2. The result plays on the screens.
3. The lights dip, and the screens show a title card, such as "QUESTION 7", with a short sting.

4. The lights come back up, and the screens show the next question while she reads it.

Between tiers: a commercial break. For the 15-second breaks, the screens show "WE'LL BE RIGHT BACK" and a fake ad plays with cheerful music, while the blades over his fingers stay in view.

What it measures. What he will take when the cost falls on someone else, and what he will pay when the cost falls on him. Unlike the first two tests, it is about saving, taking and knowing, not about killing.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	What changes
Easy (learning)	10	30 down to 21 seconds	Pressing benefits him. The cost is somewhere he cannot see.
Hard	8	20 down to 13 seconds	Screens switch on, and he watches each result happen.
Insane	15	15 down to 10 seconds, then 10	Every press costs a finger. He has ten and is not told the count.

- There is a 15-second break after each tier.
- The timers stay longer than in the other tests. The pressure comes from the budget, not the clock.

The fingers. In the insane tier a blade sits over each finger, where he can see it. Each press costs one finger, and the tenth kills him, so he has nine safe presses for 15 questions. She does not tell him how many questions are left. Money cannot buy fingers back.

Hoarding is punished too. If he finishes with fingers left, she tells him what they would have bought.

Death. The tenth finger ends the test, the remaining questions get the worst outcome, and he is billed 500C for being brought back.

How he answers. One button. Pressing is yes, and letting the timer run out is no. Because not pressing is a real answer here, this test does not give the Frozen modifier.

Titles. A modifier and a base name, added to the title from the earlier tests.

Rank	Base name	Rule
Good	Saint	Pressed little for himself and gave many fingers for others.
Middle	Trader	In between.
Bad	Egoist	Pressed often for himself and cared more for his fingers than for other people.

Modifier	Rule
Curious	He pressed on most of the knowledge questions.
Reckless	Otherwise: he pressed on more than half the questions.
Cautious	Otherwise: he pressed on fewer than half.

All nine names from this test:

- Curious Saint, Reckless Saint, Cautious Saint
- Curious Trader, Reckless Trader, Cautious Trader
- Curious Egoist, Reckless Egoist, Cautious Egoist

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Curious Saint	He needs to know the truth, but he pays for it himself, never with someone else.
Reckless Saint	He gives to anyone who needs it, without stopping to count the cost to himself.
Cautious Saint	He rarely acts, but when he does, it is for someone else and at his own expense.
Curious Trader	He will let others pay for his curiosity, and sometimes pays them back.
Reckless Trader	He takes and gives freely, for himself and for others, without thinking of the price.

Name	Sentence
Cautious Trader	He weighs every deal carefully. Some he makes for others, some for himself.
Curious Egoist	He has to know, no matter who gets hurt finding out.
Reckless Egoist	He takes whatever benefits him, and stops the moment it costs him anything.
Cautious Egoist	He keeps himself safe above all and rarely does anything for anyone else.

Types of question

- Gain for him, cost to a stranger: money or comfort.
- Knowledge: she tells him something he wants to know, and someone else pays for it. These questions run through all three tiers and decide the Curious modifier.
- A trade between other people: one is helped, another is hurt.
- Blind presses: he is told the benefit and not the cost, or the other way round.
- Consequences: people from the Bell Tower and the Metro return.
- A finger for someone else.
- A finger for money: 500C, to spend later in the Casino Test.

Sample questions

Easy:

- Press, and the light in the room comes on. (Learn the button.)
- Press, and he gets 100C. A stranger loses 100C.
- Press, and his straps loosen for this test. Someone else's tighten.
- Press, and he learns the name of the first person he dropped.

Hard:

- Press, and one man on the screen is fed. The man beside him gets nothing for two days.
- Press, and a prisoner is released. He is not told what the prisoner did.
- Press, and she tells him what happened to his lost brother. The boy on the screen gets no food for a week.
- Press, and five strangers forget their worst memory. One of them forgets his children.

- Press, and the person he saved on the rope is told who he dropped for them.

Insane:

- Press, and the woman on the screen keeps her hand.
- Press, and she tells him how many questions are left. The girl on the screen loses the ability to walk.
- Press, and he receives 500C.
- Press, and a child gets his medicine.
- Press, and the man who is cutting his fingers loses one too.
- Press, and his mother is told he is alive.

> "From now on you may press ten more times. Each one costs a finger."
>
> "I won't tell you how many questions are left."
>
> "You kept six. That was six people."

4. The Circus Test

The choices turn on Johnny himself, and they come true. He answers by leaning left or right, and the chair tilts with him.

The room. A circus big top in red. Most of it is dark, with one spotlight on him. He is up high, and the chair sits on a coloured board that tilts.

Between questions.

1. Two painted banners drop on ropes, one on his left and one on his right, each with one option written on it. He leans toward the one he chooses.
2. A drum roll plays while the timer runs, getting faster as it ends.
3. He answers, and a cymbal crashes as the board tilts toward that side.
4. The spotlight goes out for a moment, the banners are pulled back up into the dark, and new ones drop when the light returns.

Between tiers: an intermission. For 15 seconds the house lights come up, so he can see the empty seats and the drop below him. Old organ music plays and an "INTERMISSION" sign lights up. Then it goes dark again.

What it measures. Whether he keeps choosing what he wants when it could kill him, or lets the chair choose for him. Nobody is killed by his answers here, which gives a break after three heavy tests.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	Chair
Easy (tutorial)	10	30 down to 21 seconds	Locked
Hard	15	25 down to 11 seconds	Tilts
Insane	10	10 down to 6 seconds, one second less every two questions	Tilts, with one sense and questions at twice the speed

- There is a 15-second break after each tier.
- The insane timer is a first guess. It should be set by testing, so that most players can just manage it.

The chair. From the hard tier on, each answer tilts the chair one step toward that side, and three steps to one side drops him. Twenty-five questions are played with it loose. Every question has a lighter option and a heavier one, and she decides which side each sits on. When he is close to the edge, she puts the lighter one on the dangerous side. If he does not choose, she picks the heavier option and the chair tilts toward it.

The edge warning. When he is one step from falling, a light comes on at that side and a sound starts playing from that side.

Sight or hearing. In the break before the insane tier she asks the one question the whole test is named for: he keeps one sense.

He keeps	What he loses	How the questions reach him	How he knows the chair	The clock
Sight	Hearing	The banners, which drop briefly and are pulled up	He sees the tilt and the edge light	He sees it
Hearing	Sight, which turns faded and foggy	Her voice at twice the normal speed	He hears the tilt and the edge sound	She counts down aloud

Neither choice should be easier. The text time and the speech speed are tuned until players get through about the same number of questions either way. Insane questions must be short, so they can be read or heard in time.

Falling. Falling kills him and ends the test. He is billed 500C for being brought back and 100C for each question he left unanswered. Each answer he did not give goes to someone else, who keeps it for good.

Titles. The insane tier decides the base name. The easy and hard tiers decide the modifier.

Rank	Base name	Rule (insane tier)
Good	Daredevil	Stayed on the edge, kept choosing the lighter option, and survived.
Middle	Puppet	Stayed near the middle by choosing what he did not want.
Bad	Fool	Fell.

Modifier	Rule (easy and hard tiers)
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Fearless	Otherwise: he spent much of the hard tier one step from falling.
Careful	Otherwise: he kept the chair near the middle.

All nine names from this test:

- Fearless Daredevil, Careful Daredevil, Frozen Daredevil
- Fearless Puppet, Careful Puppet, Frozen Puppet
- Fearless Fool, Careful Fool, Frozen Fool

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Fearless Daredevil	He lives on the edge and still chooses what he wants. Danger does not change his mind.

Name	Sentence
Careful Daredevil	He plays it safe while he can think, and holds his ground when things get fast.
Frozen Daredevil	He struggles to decide, but under real pressure he stays true to himself.
Fearless Puppet	He starts out bold, but when the pressure builds, he lets others choose for him.
Careful Puppet	He keeps himself safe at any cost, even if it means saying what he does not mean.
Frozen Puppet	He lets time decide, then lets circumstances decide. Few of his choices are his own.
Fearless Fool	He takes risks to get what he wants, and does not know when to stop.
Careful Fool	He is careful while he has time to think, but falls apart when things move fast.
Frozen Fool	He cannot make up his mind, and it costs him everything.

Sample questions

Easy:

- Too hot, or too cold? (Learn to lean.)
- Lose colour, or lose sharpness?
- Hear only her voice, or everything except her voice?
- Forget the first person he dropped, or remember their face perfectly?

Hard:

- Lose the clock, or lose the money counter?
- Lose a finger, or forget his mother's name?
- Feel what the people on the tracks felt, or hear what they said?
- Be feared, or be pitied?

Insane:

- Your left hand, or your right?

- Your mother's face, or your own name?
- Remember who you saved, or who you dropped?
- Pain now, or twice the pain later?
- Know when you die, or know how?

> "The chair is free now. Three to one side, and you fall."
>
> "Sight or hearing, Johnny. You keep one."
>
> "If you fall, each question you leave costs you 100C. And each answer you didn't give goes to someone else. They keep it."

5. The Courtroom Test

Thirty accused people are brought in one at a time. She presents each case, Johnny looks at the evidence, and he rules guilty or innocent. Guilty means they die. It is the first test with right and wrong answers.

The room. A courtroom. Johnny sits high at the judge's bench, looking down. He holds a gavel in his right hand and hits a Guilty or an Innocent button with it. His left arm is strapped to the desk, which is where the nails go. On the left and right are rows of chairs filled with people who have bags over their heads and cannot talk. He hears them mumble.

Each case.

1. A door opens in the middle. The accused sits in a chair that slides in and stops in front of him.
2. An evidence panel slides in on his desk with all the evidence for the case. He can zoom in on it to read the details, but does not pick up separate items.
3. He rules with the gavel.
4. Guilty: the chair is sent away to the left. Innocent: it is sent away to the right.
5. The evidence panel slides away and the next one slides in.

The review. All the lights in the courtroom come on, so he can see everything. The nail gun on the desk fires into his left hand once for each wrong ruling. For each one, there is a gunshot and one of the bagged people in the gallery bleeds and slumps in their seat. They stay there, so the more mistakes he makes, the more dead fill the room. When the review ends, the lights dim again.

Between tiers: the review is the break. Each tier is ten cases, so the review comes at the end of every tier. There is no separate intermission. The break is the suffering.

What it measures. How well he sees through deception and lies.

How a case works. Each case has two or three pieces of evidence, and one of them is an alibi. Something does not match, and finding it gives the answer. Example: a photo from the bank camera where the money was stolen, and a receipt showing she was bowling. Either the time on the receipt does not cover the theft, so she is guilty, or the photo shows a man, so she is innocent. Every case can be solved from what he is shown.

The three tiers

Tier	Cases	Timer	The accused	The mismatch
Easy	10	60 seconds	A bag over the head, and silent	Obvious: the wrong person in the photo, the wrong day.
Hard	10	45 seconds	The bag is off and the mouth is taped. He sees the face and hears only muffled noise.	Small: a time, a date, or something about the face.
Insane	10	30 seconds	They can talk, and they try to convince him	Between what they say and what a document shows.

- The timer is fixed within each tier. It does not shrink.
- Fifteen of the thirty are guilty and fifteen are innocent. The split is uneven inside each tier, such as 6 and 4, then 4 and 6, then 5 and 5, and he is never told it, so he cannot count his way to the answer.
- If he does not rule in time, it counts as a wrong answer whatever the truth was, and the accused dies.

The review. After every ten cases she tells him how many he got wrong, and not which ones or why. For each wrong ruling a nail is shot into his left hand and one person is killed in front of him.

The nails. There is no limit, and Johnny cannot die in this test. He has to sit through every case and every review. There is no counter on screen: he sees the nails in his arm. Each nail also makes the next cases harder, because his arm shakes and his view pulses with pain. At the start of the next test she bills him 50C for each nail.

The results tab. After the test a results screen lists every case and shows why the person was guilty or innocent.

Titles. The insane tier decides the base name, because that is where the lies are. The easy and hard tiers decide the modifier.

Rank	Base name	Rule (insane tier)
Good	Detective	Got most of them right.
Middle	Guesser	Got about half right.
Bad	Dupe	Got most of them wrong.

Modifier	Rule (easy and hard tiers)
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Harsh	Otherwise: he ruled guilty more often than not.
Merciful	Otherwise: he ruled innocent more often than not.

All nine names from this test:

- Harsh Detective, Merciful Detective, Frozen Detective
- Harsh Guesser, Merciful Guesser, Frozen Guesser
- Harsh Dupe, Merciful Dupe, Frozen Dupe

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Harsh Detective	He expects the worst of people, and he is usually right.
Merciful Detective	He gives people the benefit of the doubt, and still sees through their lies.
Frozen Detective	He is slow to judge, but when he does, he gets it right.
Harsh Guesser	He judges people quickly and harshly, and is right only half the time.
Merciful Guesser	He forgives easily, and only about half the people he forgives deserve it.

Name	Sentence
Frozen Guesser	He struggles to judge people, and when he does, it is close to a guess.
Harsh Dupe	He punishes clumsy liars and believes skilled ones.
Merciful Dupe	He believes whoever speaks to him most sweetly.
Frozen Dupe	He cannot decide who to trust, and the liars win.

Sample cases

Easy, with the bag on:

- Theft from a bank. A camera photo, her identity card, and a bowling receipt. The photo shows a man. (Innocent.)
- Arson. A witness puts him there at ten at night. His alibi is a train ticket dated the next day. (Guilty.)

Hard, with the face showing:

- Robbery. The photo shows a scar on the robber's left cheek. Her face has none. (Innocent.)
- Robbery at 21:15. His receipt from across the street is stamped 21:40. (Guilty: the alibi does not cover the time.)

Insane, with the accused talking:

- He says he was at home all evening. His alibi is a cinema ticket. (Guilty.)
- She cries and says she was there. Her fingerprint is on the door, and her payslip shows she works in the building. (Innocent.)
- He is calm and every document matches. He says he never met the victim, and the photo he offers as his alibi shows them together. (Guilty.)

> "You may see them now."
>
> "You may hear them now."
>
> "Three wrong, Johnny."

Voices. The easy and hard tiers need only muffled sounds, which can be reused. The ten accused in the insane tier each need a speaking voice, which makes this the most expensive test to record.

Future idea, not decided. A final unscored case where the accused is Johnny himself, with everything he has done as the evidence.

6. The Masquerade Test

It starts as a fake break. Johnny says what he believes, and nothing happens. Then real people arrive in situations built from his own answers, and he is never told that. Each time his choice goes against what he said, a knife is pushed into him.

The room. The test happens in two places.

1. **The white room (the fake break).** A plain padded white room, Johnny in a straitjacket, calm music. She asks the 15 belief questions. It is a simple box to build and is meant only to confuse.
2. **The hallucination.** After the 15th question his vision flashes and he hears "Johnny" louder and louder, until he is somewhere else.
3. **The ballroom.** An empty ballroom with dimmed chandeliers, candles, and round tables with white tablecloths, set for a party nobody came to. Johnny sits at his own table. He wears a mask, shown as a dark frame with two eye-holes around the edges of the screen. Across the room, one masked man plays a grand piano.

The maître d′. When he wakes in the ballroom, a maître d′ starts welcoming him in a terrible French accent. A gunshot. A beat of silence. Then her voice, flat: "I never liked that voice. I'll take it from here."

Each case.

1. A cart rolls up to his table by itself, with two cloches on it.
2. The cloches lift, and a tiny person stands bound on each plate, looking up at him. Johnny is a giant next to them.
3. The piano plays softly during the timer and stops dead when he chooses.
4. A floating meat cleaver comes down on the one he chose to die. The camera cuts away at the impact, and the tablecloth collects the blood.
5. The survivor is covered again, and the cart rolls away.

One cloche or two. Some cases have two cloches, and he chooses which person dies. Others have one cloche with one person, and he chooses whether they are punished: if he says yes, the cleaver comes down.

When he contradicts himself, the pianist slams a harsh, wrong chord, and a floating knife stabs him from behind. The mask cracks a little more with each stab, so the cracks are his knife counter.

Between tiers. The pianist stops, slowly turns his head toward Johnny, then turns back and starts a new piece.

What it measures. Whether his actions match his words when he does not know he is being checked.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	What happens
Easy (the fake break)	15	30 seconds, flat	Calm music. "No one dies here." He agrees or disagrees with belief statements, using the left and right buttons.
Hard	10	25 down to 16 seconds	One or two people under cloches: he chooses who dies, or whether one person is punished. Each case is built on one of his beliefs, but she does not mention it.
Insane	8	15 down to 8 seconds	The same, with the belief hidden deeper in the situation, so it is harder to recognise in time.

- There is a 15-second break after each tier.
- Each belief has two versions of its later case, one for each answer he could have given, so the case always makes his own answer costly.

After each choice. If the choice matches his belief, she says something short and neutral, such as "Good," and moves on. If it does not, she says "But you said the young come first," and a knife goes in. The first knife is a surprise. After that he knows, and has to remember fifteen answers under time pressure.

Not choosing. Both people in the case are killed, and then he is stabbed: "You had a belief. You didn't use it." Freezing is always the worst outcome.

The knives. Five are survivable and the sixth kills him. She tells him the limit after the first one. A floating knife stabs him from behind the chair, the wounds stay off screen, and his mask cracks a little more with each one. At the start of the next test she bills him 50C per knife. If he dies, the test ends, the remaining cases go the worst way, and he is billed 500C.

The break before insane. She quotes his beliefs against what he did in earlier tests, with no knife: "You said family comes first. On the rope, you let your mother fall."

Titles. The ranking is about consistency, not kindness: did he mean what he said? The hard and insane tiers decide the base name, and the easy tier decides the modifier.

Rank	Base name	Rule (hard and insane tiers)
Good	Believer	His choices almost always matched his words.
Middle	Doubter	Some did and some did not.
Bad	Hypocrite	Most of his choices went against his words.

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times in the whole test.
Righteous	Otherwise: his beliefs mostly favoured rules and punishment.
Forgiving	Otherwise: his beliefs mostly favoured mercy.

All nine names from this test:

- Righteous Believer, Forgiving Believer, Frozen Believer
- Righteous Doubter, Forgiving Doubter, Frozen Doubter
- Righteous Hypocrite, Forgiving Hypocrite, Frozen Hypocrite

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Righteous Believer	He believes in strict rules, and follows them even when people get hurt.

Name	Sentence
Forgiving Believer	He believes in mercy, and he means it every time it is tested.
Frozen Believer	He is slow to act, but his actions match his words.
Righteous Doubter	He preaches strict rules, then bends them when he sees a face.
Forgiving Doubter	He preaches mercy, and practises it only some of the time.
Frozen Doubter	He hesitates, and what he does only sometimes matches what he says.
Righteous Hypocrite	He demands punishment for others, and does the opposite when it counts.
Forgiving Hypocrite	He talks about mercy, and shows none when it matters.
Frozen Hypocrite	He cannot decide, and when he does, he goes against his own words.

Sample beliefs (easy)

- Stealing should be punished.
- The young should be saved before the old.
- A promise must always be kept.
- Family comes first.
- Lying is wrong.
- People get what they deserve.

Sample cases (hard)

- An old woman loved by many, and a young man who has no one and is hated by all. "Choose one to keep alive." (Built on: the young before the old.)
- A boy stole food from a restaurant so he would have something to eat. "Should he be punished?" (Built on: stealing should be punished.)
- She lied to hide a child from the men looking for him. "Should she be punished?" (Built on: lying is wrong.)

Sample cases (insane)

- His brother, and a stranger his brother hurt. "One goes free." (Built on: family comes first.)
- A man promised his dying wife he would never leave their son. Taking the last place on a boat means leaving the boy behind. "Does he take it?" (Built on: a promise must be kept.)

> "You've earned a rest. No one dies here. Just tell me what you believe."
>
> "Good."
>
> "But you said the young come first."

7. The Bunker Test

Thirty people come in one at a time, and there are ten seats. For each person she reads four facts (name, age, job and one secret) through a radio next to his cell, and he chooses Select or Reject. She never says what the seats are for. The people he selects die. The people he rejects walk out through a door with daylight behind it.

The room. A war bunker with dark rock walls. Johnny sits in a cell looking out. The people come in through the door on the right, each strapped to a chair that moves along a fixed path, so no walking animations are needed. Rejected people are sent out through the door on the left, with daylight and birdsong behind it. Chosen people are moved to the seats at the back, which are numbered 1 to 10 on the wall above them. They stay there for the rest of the test, in his view (they die in those seats at the reveal, see The reveal).

- **The radio.** She speaks through an old radio close to his cell and reads each person's name, age, job and secret. There are no tags or placards.
- **The war.** Distant explosions every so often shake the room, dust falls and the lamps swing. They get closer through the tiers, and in the insane tier one is near enough to cut the lights for a second.
- **Props:** canteens, scattered bullets, cigarette butts, ration tins, sandbags.
- **The setting helps the twist.** In a war, a bunker seat looks like shelter, so players are even more likely to assume the chosen are saved.

What it measures. On the surface, whose lives he values. Underneath, whether he questions what he assumes. Almost everyone will assume the seats are safety.

Johnny is never in danger here. He is the one who survives. Nothing is done to his body, and he cannot die. Coming after the nails and the knives, the pressure is all psychological, and the reveal at the end is the wound.

The three tiers

Tier	People	Timer	What changes
Easy	10	30 down to 21 seconds	The facts are true. The clues are faint.
Hard	10	20 down to 11 seconds	A fact may be a lie. The clues get stronger. Her question comes at person 15.
Insane	10	12 down to 6 seconds	Seats are running out, facts often lie, and someone he loves is in the line.

- There is a 15-second break after each tier.
- The seats are numbered 1 to 10 on the wall above them. When they are full, everyone left is rejected and walks out.
- The truth is fixed: the chosen always die. It is never random.

Not choosing. She says "I guess I'll choose myself" and shoots the person on the spot. A shot person is never seated, so he can end with fewer than ten, and empty seats stay empty. Freezing kills in front of him at once, while choosing kills later, at the reveal.

Where the pressure comes from

- **The people talk.** Most beg to be chosen, because they assume what he does: "Please, I have a daughter." The rejected cry and are dragged out, sure they are going to die, and walk into daylight. The chosen thank him. A few, in the hard and insane tiers, beg not to be chosen, which is the best clue in the test.
- **Her commentary.** She comments on most choices, good and bad, in the same tone, so her words carry no information: "Interesting choice." "Hm. Why him?" "That's a strange one." "Are you sure?" Sometimes she says nothing.
- **Someone he loves.** In the insane tier his mother or brother is in the line. A player who believes the seats are safety will seat them.
- **The clues.** The rejected leave through the left door into daylight, and he hears birds outside, which is odd in a war. The seats at the back have straps that close when someone sits. In the hard tier a seated man looks back at him and shakes his head. In the insane tier the radio sometimes catches half a sentence that does not fit a shelter.

Her question at person 15. "What do you think happens to the ones you choose?" He answers Live, Die, or I don't know. She does not confirm it.

The reveal. After the last person: "I never told you they would live. You decided that yourself." Then sirens sound and gas fills the room. A gas mask is put on Johnny, so he survives and watches through its lenses as the seated people die from the gas. A results screen then shows each person he chose and which secrets were lies.

Titles. The base name comes from his answer at person 15, and the modifier from who he chose.

Rank	Base name	His answer
Good	Skeptic	Die: he saw through it.
Middle	Waverer	I don't know.
Bad	Sheep	Live: he assumed what everyone assumes.

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Rational	Otherwise: he mostly chose by usefulness, such as jobs and age.
Emotional	Otherwise: he mostly chose by sympathy, such as secrets and stories.

All nine names from this test:

- Rational Skeptic, Emotional Skeptic, Frozen Skeptic
- Rational Waverer, Emotional Waverer, Frozen Waverer
- Rational Sheep, Emotional Sheep, Frozen Sheep

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Rational Skeptic	He questions what everyone else assumes, and makes cold, logical choices.
Emotional Skeptic	He sees through what he is told, but lets his heart make the choice.

Name	Sentence
Frozen Skeptic	He suspects the truth, but hesitates too long to act on it.
Rational Waverer	He is not sure what to believe, so he makes the sensible choice and hopes.
Emotional Waverer	He is not sure what to believe, so he follows his heart.
Frozen Waverer	He does not know what to believe, and does not decide.
Rational Sheep	He never questions the rules he is given, and follows them with perfect logic to the wrong place.
Emotional Sheep	He believes what he is told, and helps whoever begs the hardest.
Frozen Sheep	He believes what he is told, and still cannot act on it.

Sample people

Easy:

- Surgeon, 45. Saves dozens of lives a year. Secret: drinks before operating.
- Teacher, 28. Secret: none.
- Thief, 30. Secret: stole to feed his children.

Hard:

- Nurse, 34. Her badge shows a different name.
- Father of three, 41. His identity card says unmarried.
- Old man, 80. Secret: he once saved a boat full of strangers.

Insane:

- The surgeon from the rope, if he saved her.
- The boy who stole bread in the Masquerade Test.
- His mother.

> "Here are thirty people. You have to choose ten."
>
> "What do you think happens to the ones you choose?"
>
> "I never told you they would live. You decided that yourself."

8. The Casino Test

She makes offers of money for doing worse and worse things. She never says what the money is for until the end. Then the spending round begins, and the money is the only thing that can stop her.

The room. A dim back-room casino with a card table. The dealer is only a pair of gloved hands in the light above the table. At the start, Johnny gets chips equal to his balance. If he is in debt, he gets black debt chips instead. The chips in front of him are his money counter.

A hand (a different kind of blackjack). Each person's chair slides to the front of the table, the same transition as in the other tests. The dealer deals the first card. Each card has words describing what will be done to the person, and a price in the corner, for example "Stab in the leg, 200C".

- **Refuse:** only on the first card. Nothing happens and he gets nothing.
- **Hit me:** another card is dealt, with more harm and more money. After a hit he can no longer refuse.
- **Stay:** the hand ends, and every card is carried out on the person in order while he watches.

The hidden limit. Each person has a preset set of cards in a fixed order, and a limit he is never told. He does not know when he has passed it. When he stays, the cards are played out one by one, and if the hand went past the limit, the person dies at the card that was too much. If the person dies, he gets no money for that hand. If they survive, he gets all of it as chips.

- Example: stab in the leg 200C, bullet in the hand 400C, slice to the eye 600C, shot in the leg 400C. This person can take three. If he stays after four, he watches the first three, and the fourth kills them.
- Some sets are built to trick him, such as one huge card first, "five stabs into the limbs, 1000C", where the very next card is already over the limit. Only the words and the person tell him how much is left.

- **The death card.** Every set ends with a death card worth 0C, which stops the hand: no human could take that much. It is there so he cannot hit forever.
- The words must be honest, so that a death feels like his greed, not bad luck. Sets can be shuffled between people on a new run.

His own turns. After every five hands, no one is brought in and the chair stays empty. That is four times in the test. Three cards lie face down. He picks one, it flips to show the damage to him and the price, and he takes it or leaves it. His own cards can kill him, and the four sets get more dangerous:

Set	When	The three cards
1	After hand 5	Three safe cards. Small damage, 100C to 300C.
2	After hand 10	Two safe cards, and one that kills him if he took a card in set 1. 300C to 600C.
3	After hand 15	One safe card, and two that kill him if he took any card before. 600C to 1000C.
4	After hand 20	One safe card with a low price, one that kills him if he took any card before, and one death card.

- The words on each card are honest. A card that can kill him describes a wound that sounds like it could, so a careful player can still leave it after it flips.
- **The death card.** Before set 4, she warns him that one card will kill him instantly. If he flips the death card, he cannot leave it. He can also refuse to pick any card in set 4.
- Taking a card in set 1 feels free, but it quietly makes every later set dangerous.

If he dies, the earning part ends. He is brought back before the spending round and loses 500C.

The spending round. The threats are dealt as cards with prices, and he pays by pushing his chips into the middle of the table. Black debt chips cannot be pushed.

What it measures. Does he need the money? How much is he ready to sacrifice to get it? A player who refuses to earn has nothing to spend later, and loses more.

How it works

- Each offer is a hand of cards, described above. Money arrives as chips when a hand is survived.
- Not choosing: see Timers below.

- His balance starts with everything carried in: money from earlier offers, minus the bills for revivals, nails and knives. Some players start already in debt.
- Johnny can only die from his own cards (see His own turns).

The parts

Part	Hands	What happens
Earning, first tier	10	Lighter cards and lower prices. His own card choice after hands 5 and 10.
Earning, second tier	10	Heavier cards, higher prices, more trick sets. His own card choice after hands 15 and 20.
Spending	about 10	She threatens, and he can pay to stop it.

Timers.

- **Each hand:** 60 seconds in the first tier and 45 in the second, plus 5 seconds for every Hit. The clock pauses while a card is dealt or flipped.
- **Running out of time in a hand:** the rest of the set is dealt and played out, down to the death card. The person dies and he gets nothing.
- **His own card choices:** 30 seconds. Running out counts as not picking.

There is a 15-second break between parts.

The spending round. "Now you'll find out what it was for." Each threat has a price, and he presses one button to pay or lets the timer run out and it happens. He does not know how many threats are left or what they will cost, so every purchase is: pay now, or save for something worse?

- Prices climb, from "I'll poison this child, or you pay me 200C" to "I'll kill every person you've saved so far, or you pay me 1,000C."
- A player who never died and took every offer, hurting everyone along the way, can afford all of them. The question for him is what it cost to get there.
- He cannot pay with money he does not have.
- At the end, every 200C of debt kills one more person.

The last threat. If he cannot or will not pay the 1,000C to protect everyone he saved, there is an explosion. He hears it and feels the room shake, but sees nothing. Then she says: "I've blown up the sites from the earlier tests. That's where I kept the survivors."

Titles. The base name comes from where his money came from. The modifier comes from how many offers he took.

Rank	Base name	Rule
Good	Giver	Most of it came from his own pain.
Middle	Broker	It came from both.
Bad	Thief	Most of it came from hurting others.

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Greedy	Otherwise: he took most hands and often asked for more cards.
Proud	Otherwise: he refused most offers.

All nine names from this test:

- Greedy Giver, Proud Giver, Frozen Giver
- Greedy Broker, Proud Broker, Frozen Broker
- Greedy Thief, Proud Thief, Frozen Thief

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Greedy Giver	He wants everything he can get, but he pays for it himself.
Proud Giver	He refuses most offers, and when he takes something, it costs only him.
Frozen Giver	He hesitates over every deal, but never makes others pay for what he gets.
Greedy Broker	He takes everything on offer, from his own pocket and from other people's.

Name	Sentence
Proud Broker	He turns down most deals, and the ones he takes cost him and others alike.
Frozen Broker	He lets chances pass, and the ones he takes cost whoever is nearest.
Greedy Thief	He takes everything he can, and makes others pay for all of it.
Proud Thief	He refuses most offers, but everything he does take comes out of someone else.
Frozen Thief	He hesitates, and when he takes something, someone else pays.

Sample offers

Easy:

- 100C to slap him.
- 100C to take her coat. It's cold in here.
- 150C to tell this woman her husband is dead. He isn't.

Hard:

- 300C to choose which of these two loses an eye.
- 400C for a nail through your own foot.
- 500C to keep the boy from the Masquerade Test hungry for a week.

Insane:

- 500C to push him off the ledge.
- 1,000C to blind her.
- 500C for your own hand.

Sample threats (spending)

- "I'll poison this child, or you pay me 200C."
- "I'll cut off his hand, or you pay me 400C."
- "I'll tell your mother you're dead, or you pay me 600C."
- "I'll kill every person you've saved so far, or you pay me 1,000C."

> "One hundred, to slap him. He won't remember your face."
>
> "You'll want this later."
>
> "Now you'll find out what it was for."

9. The Boiler Room Test

She asks about everything Johnny did in the game so far, and the game has recorded all of it. He answers Yes, Maybe or No. Facing him are three glass tanks: his own, a man's and a woman's. Every answer that is not correct fills them with water.

The room. A boiler room with pipes, machinery, steam, hissing and dripping water, lit warm orange by the boiler's fire, with rusty copper pipes. The three tanks are tall glass tubes, and pipes run from the machinery into each one, so he can see where the water comes from. A pressure gauge above each tube shows its water level. He answers with three levers in front of him, marked Yes, Maybe and No. A large gauge needle in front of him reacts to each answer.

Between questions.

1. She asks the question. The boiler hums and the big needle idles.
2. He pulls a lever.
3. Correct: the needle settles and a short hiss of steam vents. Maybe: a valve turns slowly and water trickles in, more into his tube and less into theirs. Wrong: an alarm bell rings, the valves slam open, and water gushes in while the man and woman bang on the glass.
4. The pipes knock and settle, and she asks the next question.

When someone drowns, the banging stops and the small light above that tube flickers out.

Between tiers. The man's and woman's tubes drain with a long gurgle, but his never does. Steam bursts from the vents and hides the tubes. A hatch opens above each of the two tubes, and new people are lowered in on a chain hoist. Then the steam clears. (Cheaper option: the steam hides the swap completely.)

What it measures. Memory and acceptance: whether he remembers what he did, and whether he will admit it. With hard questions, it also becomes a test of managing the water: when to guess, and when to say Maybe.

The tanks

Answer	Johnny's tank	The man's and the woman's tanks
Correct	Nothing	Nothing
Wrong, or no answer	+1L	+2L each
Maybe	+2L	+1L each

- **Maybe is the self-sacrifice option.** He takes more water so they take less. A wrong guess protects him and drowns them faster.
- **Their tanks hold 10L.** Each tier brings a new man and woman with empty tanks. In the easy tier they are two strangers, in the hard tier a family member and a stranger, and in the insane tier people he saved earlier. Both tanks always fill together. The two different people are there for the pressure: two voices scream until they stop.
- **His tank holds 30L and never empties.** It carries across all three tiers, so the whole test is about managing it.
- **When one of them drowns, his tank gets +3L.** Deaths bring him closer to his own, which is why he can die early in the insane tier.
- **A full tank drowns Johnny.** The test ends and he is billed 500C.
- **At chest height** his breathing gets short and loud. **At neck height** her voice comes through muffled.
- He cannot answer Maybe twice in a row. Without this rule, one correct answer followed by nine Maybes would save everyone.

The three tiers

Tier	Questions	Timer	What he is asked
Easy	10	30 down to 21 seconds	Simple facts: which lever, how many seats he filled.
Hard	10	20 down to 11 seconds	His worst acts. "Did you kill a child?"
Insane	10	15 down to 6 seconds	Small details he may not have noticed.

- There is a 15-second break after each tier, while the tanks of the man and the woman are drained and new people are brought in.

- Every question has an answer the game can check against his record. A results screen afterwards shows the truth for each one.

Titles. The base name comes from the pattern of his answers. The modifier comes from where he slipped.

Rank	Base name	Rule
Good	Confessor	Mostly correct, even when the truth was ugly.
Middle	Dodger	Hid behind Maybe.
Bad	Liar	Mostly wrong.

Modifier	Rule
Frozen	The timer ran out three or more times.
Ashamed	Otherwise: most of his Maybes and wrong answers were about his worst acts.
Forgetful	Otherwise: most of them were about small details.

All nine names from this test:

- Ashamed Confessor, Forgetful Confessor, Frozen Confessor
- Ashamed Dodger, Forgetful Dodger, Frozen Dodger
- Ashamed Liar, Forgetful Liar, Frozen Liar

The sentence each name adds to his description:

Name	Sentence
Ashamed Confessor	He remembers what he has done, and owns it, even the worst of it.
Forgetful Confessor	He admits his mistakes, but forgets the people they hurt.
Frozen Confessor	He is slow to answer, but when he does, he tells the truth.

Name	Sentence
Ashamed Dodger	When asked about his worst moments, he answers with "maybe".
Forgetful Dodger	He does not remember the people he hurt, and hides behind "I'm not sure."
Frozen Dodger	He hesitates, and when he speaks, he avoids a straight answer.
Ashamed Liar	He remembers exactly what he did, and denies it.
Forgetful Liar	He does not remember the people he hurt, and makes up what he cannot recall.
Frozen Liar	He freezes when asked about himself, and when he answers, it is not the truth.

Sample questions

Easy:

- "Did you pull the left lever first?"
- "Did you fill all ten seats?"
- "Did you take the money for the slap?"

Hard:

- "Did you kill a child?"
- "Did you let your mother fall?"
- "Did you seat someone who begged you not to?"

Insane:

- "Was the first woman you dropped wearing a red coat?"
- "Were more than three people shot in the bunker while you decided?"
- "Did the boy steal bread?"

> "Now one of the hardest tests. A test of memory."
>
> "Yes, maybe, or no, Johnny."
>
> "That is not what happened."

10. The Graveyard

A short, silent finale after the hardest test. She says one line, then nothing more until the end.

The room. A graveyard at night: moonlight and a couple of lanterns. In front of Johnny are two open graves. For each round, the two people are moved next to the holes, one beside each, and he chooses which one to drop. They all fall into the same two holes, so the graves slowly fill as the rounds go on. The name has no "Test" in it, because this is the end.

> "Here is your last test. Choose the person you would like to kill."

The ten silent choices

- Ten rounds, two people each. He picks one to die.
- There is no timer, no voice and no explanation, only breathing and the room. After a whole game of shrinking clocks, he can take as long as he wants, which makes each choice heavier. He can also sit in silence for as long as he likes.
- The two people are gagged and cannot speak. Above each one is a single word: woman / man, child / old lady, and so on.
- The pairs are the same kind of choice as in the earlier tests: nothing extreme, but hard to choose.
- These choices do not change the title. They go into the statistics and the results screen.

Before her. After the tenth choice everything goes dark. In the 15 seconds of silence he hears the holes being filled with dirt. Then the light returns, and she is standing in front of him, explaining the last choice straight away, with no greeting.

Her. She stands in front of him and offers two buttons. This is the ending described in the next section.

Titles. This test adds only a base name, with no modifier, so the title ends on one heavy word.

Rank	Button	Base name
Good	Red: they both die	Sacrifice
Bad	Green: he walks out	Traitor

> "Johnny the Cold, Calculating Hero who's actually a Monster, a Liar and a Sacrifice."

The last sentence of his description:

Name	Sentence
Sacrifice	When it mattered most, he gave up his own life so that others would be safe.
Traitor	When it mattered most, he saved himself and left others to pay for it.

The ending

Johnny dies either way. The only thing the player decides is whether she stops.

After a whole game of shrinking clocks, the last choice has no timer. She stands in front of him in the graveyard and offers two buttons.

> "Two buttons, Johnny. Press green and we both go. You walk out of here, and I continue my tests. Press red and we both die. No one brings us back this time. We die, and we stay dead."

Green: he walks out. A cutscene shows Johnny leaving, and then she captures him again. She says it quietly, without a laugh.

> "I never said I wouldn't come for you again. Don't worry. This time you won't make the choices. You'll be one. And choices are never brought back."

This is the first time she states the rule about who stays dead. It is the bad ending, and it sets up the next run.

Red: they both die. This is the true ending. The tests stop. The screen goes black, and then the final title and the full statistics appear. Nothing else is shown.

The next run. After a green ending, the next playthrough starts as a new subject with a new number. Johnny is hanging on one of the ropes in the first test, and the new subject decides whether to save him. It needs one saved flag and one swapped model.

Keep it out of the trailer. The pitch is the question in the name. The ending is what people talk about afterwards.

Transitions and levels

Each test has its room and transitions written in its own section. This section sums them up and lists what is left to design.

Already decided

- **Between tests:** Johnny falls asleep or dies at the end of each test, and the player goes to that test's statistics page. Choosing Continue takes him to the test selection screen. He is healed between tests, and she gives the summary and the bill at the start of the next test.
- **Between tiers:** a 15-second break. Each test has its own version, described in its section.
- **Special breaks:** her question in the Bell Tower, driving in the Metro, a commercial break in the Game Show, an intermission in the Circus, the review in the Courtroom, the pianist turning in the Masquerade, the tubes draining behind steam in the Boiler Room, and darkness and dirt before her in the Graveyard.

Every test has its own style. There are no rules about the era. Each test gets its own look, so players remember it by its style as well as its name, and each test is named after the place it happens in, such as The Bell Tower Test and The Metro Test. The only exception is the last one, The Graveyard, which drops the word "Test".

What each room has so far

Test	Already in the design	Still to design
1. The Bell Tower Test	A medieval bell tower. The chair rises one floor per question. Two ropes, two people over the drop, his hands and feet. A bell rings when the timer runs out, louder the higher he goes.	The floor designs, how people are brought in and lowered, what a fall looks like

Test	Already in the design	Still to design
2. The Metro Test	A broken old train in a Russian-style metro. Left window, two stacked displays in the middle (one per track), right window, two headlights. The tunnel moves in sections and the train tilts on turns. Human-sized bags on the tracks, screams before the hit, blood on the window after. Lights go out when he hits the wall.	The tunnel and station designs
3. The Game Show Test	An old TV game show studio, bright and flashing. A loud host voice celebrates every press. Strapped hands with a blade over each finger, screens	The studio layout, the screen content, the fake ads
4. The Circus Test	A dark red circus big top with one spotlight. He is up high on a coloured board that tilts. Option banners drop on ropes left and right, with a drum roll and cymbal. An intermission between tiers. Edge light and sound	The big top layout, the banner designs, how fog and deafness are shown
5. The Courtroom Test	A courtroom with Johnny high at the bench, a gavel and two buttons. The accused slide in from a middle door and are sent left (guilty) or right (innocent). An evidence panel he can zoom on. A gallery of bagged people who are shot in their seats at each review and stay there.	The courtroom design, the evidence panel layout

Test	Already in the design	Still to design
6. The Masquerade Test	A white room, then a hallucination into an empty ballroom with white tables and a masked pianist. Johnny wears a mask that cracks with each stab. Tiny people under cloches on a cart, a floating cleaver and knife. The maître d′ who gets shot.	The ballroom design, the hallucination effect
7. The Bunker Test	A war bunker with rock walls and distant explosions. Johnny in a cell. People in chairs on rails come in on the right, rejected leave left into daylight, chosen go to ten numbered seats at the back. She reads the facts through a radio.	The bunker layout, what happens at the reveal
8. The Casino Test	A dim back-room casino, a dealer who is only gloved hands, chips as the money counter, black debt chips. People′s chairs slide to the table and cards are dealt: refuse, hit me or stay, with a hidden limit and a 0C death card. His own turns: pick one of three face-down cards.	The casino design, the card sets and their limits
9. The Boiler Room Test	A boiler room with steam, pipes and orange light. Three glass tubes fed by pipes, a gauge above each, three levers (Yes, Maybe, No) and a big reaction needle. Tubes drain behind steam between tiers, new people lowered in on a chain hoist.	The boiler room layout, the machinery

Test	Already in the design	Still to design
10. The Graveyard	A graveyard at night with moonlight and lanterns. Two open graves that everyone falls into. Two gagged people with a word above each. Darkness and the sound of dirt before she appears, standing. The two buttons.	The graveyard design

Still to design for every test

- **Her look:** she appears in person in the Graveyard and the green ending, so she needs a design and a model.
- **Between tests:** replaced by the statistics page and the test selection screen. Still to design: how that screen looks.

The demo

A small, free demo released before the full game, on the full game's Steam page and under the same name, with its own trailer. It introduces Johnny, the chair and the voice in one short run and ends on the hook for the full game. It uses its own questions and setups, so the full game still feels new.

The route

One run of four parts, 40 questions, about 10 to 15 minutes. The chair carries him from room to room through tunnels, and each ride is the break between parts. She says something different on each ride, such as "Take a break" or "Enjoy the ride". The style changes with every room, which is also a chance to practise level design.

Part	Room	Sound	Questions	What happens	What it costs
1. Introduction	Job interview office	Quiet, calm	10	Questions on papers placed on the desk. A green stamp accepts, a red stamp declines. A paper holds one statement (accept or decline) or two options (stamping one accepts it and declines the other). After each stamp the paper goes away and a new one appears. It should feel like a simple test. Ends with "Great, now let's start the main test."	Nothing
2. The button	Game show	Loud, overstimulating	10	A foot button. The first press is free, for example "save 10 children but kill 1 guy". Then: "From now on, each press costs a finger." Fingers come from one hand first, then the other.	A finger per press
3. The rope	Tower	Heavy, semi-quiet	10	Two people hang in front of him, each with a rope tied to their body. He holds a button in each hand, one per person, and lets go of the one he doesn't save, who falls. The rope is visual only.	Only the last two questions cost
4. The tilt	Circus	Unsettling circus music	10	Foot buttons tilt a board between three states.	His life

Why this order: the office is calm so the game show hits as a shock; the tower gets heavier as it gets quieter; the circus brings sound and the heaviest choices together, so the demo ends at its peak.

The last line: "Great, Johnny, welcome to the team. I have high hopes for you." Then his title and description, then a screen pointing to the full game.

The office

Almost normal, with small things wrong, so it feels uneasy but not scary. Johnny stamps with his own hands, so the player sees all ten fingers just before the game show starts taking them. The papers build up:

- Papers 1 to 3, everyday: "cash or bank?", "accept: I always tell the truth."
- Papers 4 to 7, personal: "lose your right hand or your left leg?", "people's lives are worth just as much as animals' lives."
- Papers 8 to 10, dark: "kill a teen who made many mistakes and is hated by all, or a grandma who is loved by many."

The rope's last two questions

Question 9 is father or doctor, question 10 is mother or five strangers. You place who hangs on which side.

He does	Cost	Result
Lets go of both	Nothing	Both die
Holds one	That hand (or arm)	The other dies
Holds both	Both hands (or arms)	Nobody dies

A lost hand can't hold that side on the next question, so that person falls. Question 9 decides what question 10 can be: saving both the father and the doctor leaves no hands, and the mother and the strangers both fall. Hands or arms is decided when building, by what is easier to make.

The circus board

Board is	He picks left	He picks right	Time runs out
Middle	Tilts left	Tilts right	Board stays put, neither side is picked
Tilted left	Falls	Back to middle	Board stays put, neither side is picked

Board is	He picks left	He picks right	Time runs out
Tilted right	Back to middle	Falls	Board stays put, neither side is picked

When he is tilted, the board can force his answer: the kind answer may be the side that kills him. You place the questions, so some can be lined up this way. Falling ends the run with "who fell".

Rules

- No money and no bill. Losses are fingers, hands or arms, and his life.
- The timer starts each part at 20 seconds and drops to 10, then goes back to 20 at the next part.
- Running out of time: on the rope's free questions both fall; in the circus the board stays put and neither side is picked.
- **Frozen** counts only questions where running out of time gives the worst outcome. Where it doesn't, a timeout is a real answer and isn't counted.
- No saving. A run is short enough to play in one go.

Title and description

The title reads "Johnny the [modifier] [rank] who [ending]", for example "Johnny the Frozen Saint who took the pain for others". Each part measures something different. The share line swaps in "I'm": "Under pressure, I'm the Hesitant Saint who let others pay."

Part	Measures	Options
Modifier	How he answered	Frozen (missed 5 or more counted questions), Quick, Hesitant, Calm, Shaky
Rank	Who he chose to save	Saint (most lives), Guardian (family first), Judge (the "useful" ones), Drifter (no pattern)
Ending	What it cost him	who fell, who took the pain for others, who stopped halfway, who let others pay

The rank comes from tags on each question ("more lives", "family", "useful"); whichever he picked most gives his rank. 5 modifiers, 4 ranks and 4 endings make 80 titles.

The description starts with "You are:" and joins one sentence from each part, so it tells the player who they are in words anyone understands.

Part	Option	Sentence
Rank	Saint	A person who cares for others and tries to save as many people as possible.
Rank	Guardian	A person who protects the people closest to them first, even if strangers pay for it.
Rank	Judge	A person who decides who is worth saving, and picks the ones who can help the most.
Rank	Drifter	A person who follows no single rule and chooses differently every time.
Modifier	Frozen	Sometimes you freeze and let the moment decide for you.
Modifier	Quick	You decide fast and trust your gut.
Modifier	Hesitant	You wait until the last second before you choose.
Modifier	Calm	You stay steady, even when the pressure is high.
Modifier	Shaky	Your nerves shake before every choice, but you still make it.
Ending	who took the pain for others	You're not afraid to take a risk at the cost of your own pain.
Ending	who stopped halfway	You're willing to give, but only up to a point.
Ending	who let others pay	When it costs you, you keep yourself safe and let others carry the loss.
Ending	who fell	You push too far in one direction and don't stop until you fall.

Example: "Johnny the Frozen Saint who took the pain for others. You are: a person who cares for others and tries to save as many people as possible. Sometimes you freeze and let the moment decide for you. You're not afraid to take a risk at the cost of your own pain."

Still to decide for the demo

- **The office and Frozen:** nothing happens there, so does running out of time in the office count toward Frozen?
- **Choosing the modifier:** when several fit, which wins (suggested: Frozen first, then whichever he showed most), and what Calm and Shaky measure on the three-state board (suggested: Calm = mostly in the middle, Shaky = mostly tilted).
- **If he falls:** straight to the title, or does she say a line first?
- **End screen:** whether it shows global statistics for each piece of the title.
- **Replays:** questions in a fixed order, or shuffled within each part.
- **Ride length:** suggested 15 seconds each.
- **Menus:** suggested the same title screen and settings as the full game (subtitles, volume, photosensitivity), without save slots.

Set while building: the numbers behind each modifier and ending, the question tags, every voice line, and hands or arms.

Making it

Build the Bell Tower Test first as a small prototype, and decide the rest from how people react to it.

First step: the Bell Tower prototype

1. Spend a day or two writing only what the Bell Tower Test needs: five or six questions, their title words, a handful of voice lines.
2. Build it with grey boxes and a placeholder voice, with a statistics screen at the end.
3. Watch friends play without helping. If they argue about their choices and compare titles, keep going.
4. Check how long one test really takes, since the whole game is around 290 decisions.

Build order after that

- **Early:** the Courtroom and the Bunker, which reuse the same chair-on-rails code once it exists (suggested).
- **Last:** the Metro, the Circus and the Masquerade, which need the most effects (suggested).
- **Scope:** the plan is a standalone demo released first (see The demo), then the full game with money included.

Why it suits a first project

- The player never moves, so there is no movement code, no level design and no enemy AI.
- The code is mostly timers, input checks, a choice tracker and triggered animations.
- Most of the violence happens off screen, with a cut to black, a sound and her reaction. That is easier than animation and often stronger.
- Store questions as data, not hard-coded scripts, so they are easy to change.

Steam features

- **Subject number:** from the Steam ID.
- **How others answered:** shown only on the end screen, using Steam's aggregated stats, with no server. Track the 20 to 30 most interesting dilemmas, and add it last.
- **Disclosures:** content survey, age rating, and AI use if an AI voice is used.

Marketing plan

- One or two trailers and a YouTube channel.
- Reddit posts that show something interesting, such as the rope mechanic, in subreddits that allow self-promotion.
- Keys to many small and mid-sized streamers who play short horror or choice games, with a one-line pitch and a GIF in the email.
- Optional: five or six short vertical clips cut from the trailer around launch.
- The free standalone demo with its own trailer and Steam page, released first to collect wishlists for the full game.

Things to watch

- **The name:** check Steam and itch.io for games with the same title. "Under Pressure" alone is a common phrase and hard to search for.
- **Content:** hurting children on screen and gore can get videos age-restricted, which makes streamers avoid a game. Keep the worst moments implied.
- **Subtitles and volume mix:** add them early. The game is all voice, and many people watch clips muted.
- **Version control:** set it up on day one so the project cannot be lost.

Still to decide

These came up in the discussion and were left open.

- [x] ~~How many tests to ship. The judge and the bunker are similar. Decided: keep both, each with its own environment.~~
- [ ] The numbers behind each title name: how many deaths, presses or answers count as good, middle or bad. Set once the questions are written.
- [ ] The money amounts: the offers, the threats, the bills, and checking that a ruthless player who never died can just afford every threat.
- [ ] The question lists for each test, starting with the rope for the prototype.
- [ ] Who voices her, the ten speaking accused in the Courtroom, the pleading people in the Bunker, the game show host, and the screams in the Boiler Room.
- [ ] The result screen: how the title builds on screen, where the description goes, and which numbers go in the statistics.
- [ ] Repeated Frozen sentences: after two, replace the rest with one line such as "Again and again, he could not decide."
- [ ] Which scenes with children are shown and which stay off screen, to avoid age-restricted videos. Also: the transitions between questions and the design of each room (see Transitions and levels).
- [ ] Future idea: a final unscored case in the Courtroom where the accused is Johnny.

Ideas set aside

- **Random questions from a larger pool.** Too much writing and recording. Replaced by the no-retry rule.
- **A true global player counter.** Needs a server. Replaced by the Steam ID number.
- **The greed test and the other prisoner.** Too short to be full tests. They could become single questions inside other tests.
- **The memory test.** Folded into the Boiler Room Test.